just meant to be a statutory warning of sorts, but not for me. Dada had always acted older than his age when it came to being the elder brother. Tall and handsome, he was dressed in a check shirt tucked neatly into his jeans, as he stood next to me. There was a grimace on his thin, chiselled face as his eyes scanned the bogie. To him, his little sister would always be immature and inexperienced, but he wouldn't counsel her, he wouldn't express his concerns—he would simply threaten those he thought meant her harm, even if they actually didn't.

The train horn blew for the last time, signalling its departure. Maa and Dada said their goodbyes and left. But Papaji stayed on. 'I haven't even prepared for the SSB, Papaji. I feel like I'm on the edge here,' I said.

'That's where you belong . . . on the edge . . . since you were a child,' he gently cupped my chin in his battle-hardened hands and looked as if reminiscing. Then, after a pause, he said, 'Besides, no preparations are required for things that are meant to be . . . '

I was just another girl before I became Flight Lieutenant Gunjan Saxena, before I actively took part in the 1999 Kargil War, where India emerged victorious in the face of heavy odds, before I was felicitated with the Shaurya Vir Puraskar by the Uttar Pradesh government, before I came to be known as the 'Kargil Girl'. I was just another girl with dreams in her eyes and passion in her heart, clueless on board the train that would take her on the journey of her lifetime. Shortlisted for the SSB for the 4th Short Service Commission for Women pilot course in 1994, I was both nervous and excited as the train journey commenced—excited because I had grown up dreaming of wearing the uniform my father wore, and nervous because I was about to appear for the SSB interview, unprepared. Of the thirteen SSBs across India, I was selected to appear for the one in Mysore, which was primarily for shortlisted candidates for the Indian Air Force. All I knew about SSB was that it would evaluate my suitability for becoming an officer using a standardized protocol evaluation system, which comprises personality and intelligence tests, both written and practical-task-based, and interviews, and that the evaluation process would take five to six days. The evaluation would be to determine whether or not I possessed the fifteen